RED THREAD

Colour psychology & combination guide

Wafiq · Personal brand system · Version 1.0

Crimson	Coral	Plum	Sand	Canary Yellow
#EB0E31	#FDA2AC	#33212C	#D8CFC2	#E7C75A

The short version

This is a crimson-led identity supported by plum, coral, sand and canary yellow. The intended impression is bold and expressive, with plum and sand supplying editorial control. The psychology section below describes research-backed associations, not guaranteed reactions or universal meanings.

1. What colour psychology research actually says

A 2025 systematic review by Jonauskaite and Mohr synthesised 132 peer-reviewed studies, 42,266 participants and 64 countries. It found systematic colour–emotion associations, but also emphasised that associations are many-to-many and are influenced by hue, lightness and saturation. Most studies tested abstract associations; whether those associations reliably translate into real-world behaviour or specific design outcomes remains less certain.

Red: associated with high-arousal and empowering emotions, but the associations can be positive (such as passion or excitement) or negative (such as anger or hostility). It is not simply a universal “confidence” or “urgency” switch.

Pink: more often associated with positive emotions in the review, including love, fun and happiness. The exact shade and context matter; the brand's coral-pink is highly saturated compared with some soft pinks.

Purple family: purple was associated with some empowering emotions. Plum is a dark red-purple, so treating it as a grounding, sophisticated brand colour is a design interpretation, not a direct experimental finding about this exact hex value.

Yellow: yellow and orange were associated with positive, high-arousal emotions such as joy, pleasure, fun and excitement. Canary Yellow can therefore provide a lively accent, but excessive saturation or area may compete with crimson.

Sand / warm neutral: the research does not establish a specific psychological effect for `#D8CFC2`. Its role here is an art-direction choice: a low-chroma, warm neutral that softens the contrast between the strong crimson and dark plum.

2. How the five colours work as a system

Crimson (#EB0E31) — signature and emphasis. Its high saturation gives the identity energy and visual force. Use it for the primary brand mark, decisive headlines, selected panels and key actions. Because red can carry both positive and negative associations, balance it with calmer surfaces and clear information hierarchy.

Plum (#33212C) — depth and structure. Use it for dark backgrounds, navigation, headings and long-form reading surfaces. It makes the system feel less stark than pure black. The “editorial authority” role is an intentional brand-design interpretation.

Coral (#FDA2AC) — warmth and approachability. Use for secondary panels, graphic blocks, illustration fields and supporting highlights. Pair it with plum text for legibility.

Sand (#D8CFC2) — breathing room. Use as a warm light surface, document background or text colour on dark fields. It does not need to dominate every page; dark plum and crimson-led compositions are part of the identity.

Canary Yellow (#E7C75A) — surprise and signal. Use sparingly for numbering, small markers, underlines, tags and selected graphic details. Plum is the preferred text colour on yellow.

3. Recommended combinations

Combination	Role	How to use it
Plum + Sand	Default editorial pairing	Plum background with Sand text, or Sand surface with Plum text. Strong for reading, case studies and documents.
Crimson + Sand	Signature statement	Crimson hero panel, Sand headline or logo. Use for high-priority moments, not every section.
Plum + Coral	Expressive but controlled	Coral panels with Plum typography. Good for quotes, profile cards and secondary sections.
Crimson + Coral	Warm, high-energy pairing	Use as neighbouring blocks, bands or large shapes. Avoid small text directly over the other colour.
Plum + Canary Yellow	High-visibility accent	Yellow marker, label or underline against Plum. Use for small bursts of emphasis.
Crimson + Plum	Dramatic brand pairing	Use Crimson as a contained block or accent against Plum. Keep typography Sand or white and check contrast.

4. Practical rules for human-facing design

• Use colour to establish hierarchy, not to replace labels or clear wording.

• Reserve the brightest crimson for the most important action or message in a given view.

• Use Plum for body text on Sand, Coral and Yellow surfaces.

• Use Sand or white for text on Plum and Crimson, but verify contrast for the actual font size and weight.

• Avoid Coral-on-Crimson and Yellow-on-Sand for small text.

• Do not make every screen crimson-led. A strong identity needs contrast and pacing.

• Check the palette on calibrated displays, mobile screens and in print. Colour reproduction varies by device, paper and lighting.

5. Important limitations

Colour associations are not fixed personality traits, and they do not reliably predict an individual's reaction. Culture, language, prior experience, surrounding colours, brightness, saturation, task and industry conventions all influence interpretation. The research supports cautious design decisions, not claims such as “red makes everyone trust you” or “yellow guarantees attention.” Treat this guide as a reasoned design framework and validate it with real portfolio users.

6. Research sources

• Jonauskaite, D. & Mohr, C. (2025). “Do we feel colours? A systematic review of 128 years of psychological research linking colours and emotions.” Psychonomic Bulletin & Review, 32, 1457–1486.
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https://doi.org/10.1037/gpr0000170

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Prepared for Wafiq's personal brand system. Research summaries are paraphrased; consult the original papers for methods, limitations and full findings.